[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, January 5, 1847*

I trust this will find you in England and that you will finally find it to your advantage to settle there, perhaps I have adopted some of the Persian fear of water travelling, but I can not but think of the risks you run in going backwards and forward from England to America, particularly when I see accounts in the newspapers of the accidents which happen to the Great Britain[106] and the other large steamers. We have as yet no news as to whether they have succeeded in getting this unfortunate ship off or not, as the last news we have from Europe is the 10*th* November from Paris. We expect the monthly post in two or three days when we shall most likely have news up to the 10*th* Decr from Paris.

The Prince still keeps me translating from the natural history, which he is exceedingly I was going to say childishly fond of. The work I want to be about is a translation of a Gazeteer, which I could do now having found a Turkish Geography from which I could get the spelling of the names of the places in the Arabic letters, which would do for the Persian. I do not like these animals at all, translating natural history does me no good, and perhaps not much more to the Prince. But he who pays the piper has a right to choose the tune. He is remarkably fond of pictures and paints a little himself. He has a large collection of pictures chiefly copper plates, some of them pretty good ones, amongst these he has a large book full of the figures of animals; he looks this over and over and then tells me to write the history of any which take his fancy. Now the Gazeteer would be a respectable work, and besides if I finished it, and presented a copy to the King, it might do me good in many ways. You will perhaps be surprised to hear that we have now in Tabreez no less than sixteen printing establishments, and more in Tehran, in fact books have become so cheap in Persia that it has done much injury to the trade of the copyists; still very fine manuscripts hold their price and there are several copies of the Shah-Nāmeh (the Persian Homer) which could not be bought for less than a hundred pounds and you might perhaps buy a printed one for as many sixpences.[107]

You will be glad to hear that the cholera has ceased here and that I and my friends (except poor Glen at Tehran) have been spared. It is supposed to have carried off from 15 to 20,000 of the inhabitants of this province, and perhaps nearly as many from some of the other provinces of Persia. I sincerely trust

[106] The *Great Britain*, launched in 1843, was the largest iron steamboat of her time. She was operated successfully on the trans-Atlantic run until she went aground on the Irish coast, September, 1846. Although exposed to the elements for eleven months, she was refloated and continued in service for some time afterwards. Cf. E. K. Cheverton, *Steamships and their story*, London, 1911, p. 123 ff.

[107] The New York Public Library has a very fine illuminated and illustrated ms. copy of the Shāhnāmeh in the Spencer Collection; for its description by the late Prof. Gottheil, cf. its *Bulletin*, v. 30, p. 343-354.

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